When Disability Becomes Inheritance:

Rethinking Bangladesh's Freedom Fighter Quota System

Op-Ed

I was ten years old when I first heard the term "freedom fighter quota." At that age, it did not seem harmful, almost deadly, to civilians. I imagined it as a way for the country to honor the people whose sacrifices built Bangladesh, where I grew up. But my understanding was flawed. I later learned that this quota was not just for the veterans themselves but also for their children, grandchildren, and even great-grandchildren, as long as documentation connected them to someone affected by the 1971 war (Rozario, 2018).

As a teenager newly exposed to real-world dynamics, the July Revolution of 2024 made me aware of the deeply flawed system when students across Bangladesh poured into the streets. The protests focused on fairness, merit, corruption, and political misuse (Hasnat S., 2024). However, there was something else beneath the surface that few seemed to name: How did disability become a form of inheritance? Why was it used as a political identity rather than a lived experience? This year, in my critical disability studies course, I learned concepts that helped me organize my thoughts and reflect on this issue. I found global disability activism closely tied to what I witnessed last year in Bangladesh. We learned that disability is not just a medical label; it is a political category that states create and use to distribute resources and legitimacy. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson describes disability as a system that organizes exclusion and privilege, not simply a bodily condition (Garland-Thomson, 2014). Eli Clare (2017) writes that liberation requires dismantling the structures that determine whose bodies are valued and whose are dismissed. This gave more sense to the civilians' frustration regarding the quota system in Bangladesh.

When we look at Bangladesh's quota system historically, we see how disability became part of national identity. After independence, the state reserved 30% of civil service jobs for freedom fighters. Later, it extended eligibility to their children (1997) and grandchildren (2010) (Daily Star, 2024). What began as recognition for those physically or mentally affected by war became a hereditary entitlement linked to ancestry rather than ability. In 2024, after the High Court reinstated the 30% quota, mass protests erupted, leading the Supreme Court to reduce the allocation to 5% (Stambaugh et al., 2024).

The main controversial issue is that the policy uses the language of disability without focusing on people who are actually disabled today. Someone who lost mobility in a car accident last year faces far more barriers, including architectural, social, and economic challenges, than a perfectly able-bodied great-grandchild of a 1971 freedom fighter. Yet the latter may receive benefits unavailable to the former. This is not a critique of freedom fighters. It critiques how the state has used disability as symbolic currency.

During the 2024 protests, even some beneficiaries recognized this disconnect. In The Daily Star, one student said, "I used the freedom fighter quota... but I would not deprive someone of a well-deserved opportunity today" (Azra, 2024). Another noted that despite the large 30% allocation, the posts often remained unfilled due to a lack of eligible candidates, showing that those most "eligible" on paper were not necessarily those needing support (Azra, 2024). Disability justice teaches us that support should not be based on lineage but on lived barriers. Mia Mingus argues that justice requires centering "those most impacted," not those historically adjacent to impact (Mingus, 2011). When disability becomes inheritance rather than lived experience, it stops functioning as justice and turns into a political tool. The quota system had good intentions—to honor sacrifice, repair trauma, and rebuild a devastated nation. However, policies must evolve as citizens' needs change. Honoring history should not overshadow the structural barriers disabled people in Bangladesh face today: inaccessible schools and workplaces, limited mobility infrastructure, and deep social stigma.

If we truly want equality, we have to ask: **Who does the language of disability serve? Who does it leave out?**

Reform does not mean erasing history. It means shifting our focus from past suffering to present barriers. It means ensuring that people who are disabled now—whether through illness, accident, war, or environmental factors—receive the support they need to live with dignity. Bangladesh does not need to abandon gratitude for its freedom fighters. But gratitude should not dictate civil service recruitment for generations. Nor should disability be inherited like property. As students across the country demanded in 2024, we need a quota system rooted in fairness, transparency, and real disability justice—one that reflects current realities, not just historical memory.

If disability is to be taken seriously as a political identity, it must belong to those who live it, not to those who merely inherit its shadow.

Reflection

In my op-ed When Disability Becomes Inheritance, I wanted to translate the complex idea that disability is a political construct into a form that people outside the classroom could understand. Instead of explaining theory abstractly, I grounded the piece in my experience growing up in Bangladesh and witnessing the 2024 quota protests. I used my personal confusion as a child and later frustration as a young adult to show how disability can be weaponized, inherited, and distorted by state policy. My aim was to make readers rethink how governments use "disability" symbolically to grant benefits and legitimacy while ignoring the real barriers disabled people face today.

My target audience is not limited to Bangladeshis. I wrote this for anyone politically engaged, especially those thinking about state power, human rights, or activism but rarely questioning how

disability categories are created and used. This includes students, activists, policy analysts, journalists, and people who follow global movements, like the Korean transit protests or the Bolivian disability rights marches, that we studied in class. Many of these readers understand political injustice, but they may not yet recognize how disability becomes a political identity shaped and controlled by governments. I wanted to speak to people who analyze protests and policy failures but haven't applied disability theory as an interpretive lens.

The piece is directly informed by the disability studies material we covered. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's (2014) argument that disability is a system that organizes exclusion and privilege helped me articulate why the quota system felt wrong to me even as a child. It was never about lived disability; it was about distributing privilege symbolically. Eli Clare's (2017) writing on liberation and dismantling oppressive structures shaped how I framed the state's use of historical trauma to justify inherited advantage. And Mia Mingus's (2011) principle of centering "those most impacted" clarified the core issue: disability justice cannot function if disability becomes hereditary, detached from real barriers in the present. For historical grounding, I drew on journalism from The Daily Star, the New York Times, and CNN, which provided factual accounts of the 2024 protests and direct testimonies from quota beneficiaries. Including these sources allowed me to situate theoretical ideas within a concrete political crisis that unfolded in real time. By combining academic disability theory with contemporary reporting, I tried to bridge the gap between the world of scholarly critique and the world of lived political conflict. Ultimately, in this op-ed, I aimed to expand the conversation about Bangladesh's quota system by introducing a disability justice perspective that is almost entirely missing from mainstream debate. I wanted readers to see that the issue is not only about fairness or corruption; it is about how governments decide whose disability counts, whose pain is acknowledged, and whose access is ignored. Writing this op-ed helped me realize how much disability studies reshapes my interpretation of protest, nationalism, and policy. My hope is that others—especially politically engaged readers—begin to see disability as a living, contested, and deeply political identity that must belong to those who actually experience it.

References

1. Rozario, Rock Ronald (2018). "Bangladesh's 'unfair' civil service quota system under fire." *Union of Catholic Asian News.* https://www.ucanews.com/news/bangladeshs-unfair-civil-service-quota-system-under-fire/81722#google_vignette
2. Hasnat, Saif (2024). "Tens of Thousands of Students Protest Job Quotas in Bangladesh's Streets." *The New York Times.* https://www.nytimes.com/2024/07/11/world/asia/bangladesh-student-protests-job-quotas.html
3. Garland-Thomson, R. (2014). *The story of my work: How I became disabled*. Disability Studies Quarterly. Garland-Thomson | The Story of My Work: How I Became Disabled https://dsq-sds.org/article/id/70/
4. Clare, E. (2017). "The Ferocious Need for Liberation." *Disability Studies Quarterly* 37
5. History of the quota system in Bangladesh. (2024, July 10). *The Daily Star*. https://www.thedailystar.net/news/bangladesh/news/history-the-quota-system-bangladesh-3653326
6. Stambaugh, A., Suri, M., & Liakos, C. (2024). Bangladesh's top court rolls back most government job quotas after violent protests. *CNN*. https://www.cnn.com/2024/07/21/asia/bangladesh-supreme-court-rolls-back-job-quotas-intl
7. Azra, H. (2024). *Students and quota holders say reform is necessary*. The Daily Star. https://www.thedailystar.net/campus/campus/news/students-and-quota-holders-say-reform-necessary-3654446

8. Mingus, M. (2011). Changing the framework: Disability justice. *Leaving Evidence*. https://leavingevidence.wordpress.com